

NERAI Sanctions Weekly

The week's most consequential events, selected by strategic consequence and grounded in a 106-article 7-day corpus plus live NERAI data. CORRECTED EDITION - supersedes the first issue of this week.

THE WEEK IN BRIEF - Two threads dominated. The 60-day US–Iran deadline expired on 17 August with no permanent deal — though the interim framework it belonged to had already unravelled weeks earlier — and Washington is preparing a further economic-pressure package. Separately, Putin threatened on 12 August to seize European vessels in retaliation for enforcement against Russian-linked ships, moving the shadow-fleet contest from designation lists toward physical interdiction. A third item, ONGC's disclosure of expanded OFAC authorisation for Venezuela, is carried as a follow-up rather than a new action.

01 US–Iran 60-Day Deadline Expires as Washington Prepares Further Economic Pressure

NEW EVENT | event date: 2026-08-17

WHY IT RANKS - The deadline's expiry removes the last formal framework restraining escalation, and Washington has signalled a further pressure package within days.

The 60-day deadline set under the US–Iran interim understanding expired on 17 August 2026 without a permanent agreement. The interim framework it belonged to had already largely collapsed weeks earlier, following exchanges of fire involving shipping and the withdrawal of oil waivers; the expiry is the formal end of a framework that had ceased to function in practice, not the loss of a working ceasefire. On 13–14 August the US Treasury Secretary indicated that further economic-isolation measures would be announced, with 'teapot' refineries in China processing Iranian crude identified in public discussion as one pressure point.

STRATEGIC ANALYSIS - The policy question is no longer whether pressure resumes but which instrument carries it. Naval interdiction is already in force, so the realistic escalation path is the tightening and widening of existing measures — additional designations, secondary exposure for Chinese independent refiners, and pressure on the intermediaries that clear payment. Targeting teapot refineries would place Beijing directly in the enforcement path, a materially different risk to a shipping-only campaign. For compliance teams the near-term exposures are counterparties in crude trading, refined-product offtake and the payment chains behind them.

NERAI SIGNAL - Restricted-party context (not a severity ranking): Iran 1,110 entries, China 2,406 entries in NERAI's aggregated register — record counts, not measures of transaction risk. NERAI's circumvention corridors are calibrated on Russia-bound flows and are cited only as an analogy for how enforcement pressure redirects trade through third countries; they are not evidence about Iran-related diversion.

Sources: omanobserver.om: <https://www.omanobserver.om/article/1194599/world/region/us-iran-miss-60-day-deadline-to-reach-war-deal> | military.com: <https://www.military.com/us-readies-unprecedented-economic-isolation-plan-for-iran>

02 Putin Threatens Retaliatory Vessel Seizures as UK Defends Earlier Shadow-Fleet Enforcement

NEW EVENT | event date: 2026-08-12

WHY IT RANKS - The contest over Russia's shadow fleet moves from designation toward the threat of physical seizure, which changes voyage, security and insurance exposure rather than screening obligations.

On 12 August 2026 President Putin stated that Russia would begin seizing European vessels if Russian merchant ships continue to be targeted, and Russia warned that the EU is 'bringing great dangers upon itself'. On 13 August the UK publicly defended its detention of a shadow-fleet tanker — an enforcement action taken earlier in the year, not during this window. Russia's Pacific Fleet commander separately stated that Russian forces have the capacity to inspect and detain vessels of hostile states.

STRATEGIC ANALYSIS - This is the first credible signal that shadow-fleet enforcement could produce reciprocal interdiction rather than only legal and commercial consequences. The chain that matters runs: sanctions enforcement, to physical detention, to possible Russian retaliation, to voyage-planning, security and insurance exposure. Consequences here are conditional, not automatic — a seizure incident could trigger P&I; and sanctions-cover reviews, flag-state guidance and upward pressure on war-risk pricing on exposed routes. Operators transiting areas where Russian interdiction is plausible should reassess voyage risk and crew guidance ahead of any incident rather than after one.

NERAI SIGNAL - Russia fossil-fuel export revenue: EUR 683 mn/day (July 2026, CREA — revised down 12% month-on-month; the May 2026 reading of EUR 726 mn/day is superseded). NERAI Russia enforcement-pressure index: 44.7 (as of 17 August 2026).

Sources: arabnews.com: <https://www.arabnews.com/node/2654399/world> | bbc.co.uk: <https://www.bbc.co.uk/news/articles/cn0npn249qvo> | aa.com.tr: <https://aa.com.tr/en/world/russia-warns-eu-is-bringing-great-dangers-upon-itself-by-seizing-vessels/4025693>

03 FOLLOW-UP — ONGC Discloses Expanded OFAC Authorisation for Venezuela Operations

FOLLOW-UP - underlying action predates this window | event date: 2026-08-16

WHY IT RANKS - A significant carve-out in the Venezuela regime, carried as a follow-up because the authorisation itself predates this window — the new element is the disclosure of its scope.

Indian reporting on 16–17 August 2026 stated that ONGC holds an OFAC licence permitting full resumption of its Venezuelan operations, and that the company is pursuing operatorship of assets there. The underlying authorisation is not new to this window: on 5 August Reuters reported ONGC's finance director describing 'full freedom to work' in Venezuela. The full text of the licence is not public, so its exact conditions, covered entities, duration and limitations are not established.

STRATEGIC ANALYSIS - The pattern is more informative than the instrument: OFAC is using specific licences as a geopolitical tool, enabling an Indian state company where broader Venezuela restrictions remain. That complicates third-party due diligence, because licence coverage is counterparty-specific and unpublished. Operators should not infer any general relaxation, and should verify confirmed ONGC involvement and the licence's scope directly rather than assuming coverage extends along a transaction chain.

NERAI SIGNAL - OFAC SDN list: 19,199 entries (NERAI register, as of 17 August 2026). No inference about licence scope is drawn from NERAI data — the licence text is not in the public record.

Sources: moneycontrol.com:

<https://www.moneycontrol.com/news/business/companies/ongc-gets-us-licence-to-resume-full-venezuela-operations-eyes-operatorship-14006646.html> | business-standard.com:

https://www.business-standard.com/markets/capital-market-news/ongc-receives-ofac-license-to-continue-full-operations-in-venezuela-126081700361_1.html

WITHHELD BY THE TEMPORAL GATE - OFAC Largest-Ever CJNG Sanctions Action (event dated 2026-07-23 (Treasury press release; OFAC recent actions 20260723) — a law-firm commentary published 13 August does not place the action in this window)

CORRECTIONS IN THIS EDITION - (1) CJNG event withdrawn — OFAC acted 23 July 2026; the 13 August date was a law-firm commentary's publication date. (2) Russia fossil revenue corrected to EUR 683 mn/day (July 2026, CREA) from EUR 726 mn/day (May 2026 reading). (3) US–Iran headline reframed: the deadline expiry ends a framework that had already unravelled, not a functioning ceasefire. (4) Blockade framing corrected: naval interdiction is already in force; the realistic path is tightening, not initiation. (5) Insurance consequence made conditional: 'could trigger P&I; and sanctions-cover reviews', not 'would trigger immediate P&I; club exclusions'. (6) Russia circumvention corridors cited as an analogy for enforcement displacement only, not as evidence about Iran-related diversion. (7) Country restricted-party counts presented as context; the 'third-most-sanctioned country' ranking claim removed. (8) ONGC re-classed as FOLLOW-UP with the earlier 5 August reporting cited; no inference drawn about the unpublished licence text.

Grounded generation: events are selected only from the week's retrieved article corpus and NERAI feeds; every event carries its sources; each event states the date the issuing authority acted, which is distinct from the date any article about it was published; quantitative figures carry their observation period; maximum five events, fewer when the week is thin. NERAI-UNRESTRICTED.